THE SECRET OF MODES

JAZZ LAB MUSIC



A HANDS-ON TOOLKIT FOR UNDERSTANDING, IMPROVISING, AND COMPOSING WITH MODES

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INTRO



There is a lot of confusion and misinformation when it comes to musical modes. Modes are basically as old as music, and have been used in many different ways across different cultures in the globe.

Differently than traditional scales (which are simply a sequence of pitches), modes are group of notes with a specific "taste", a "vibe", a hierarchy between the notes, and very specific melodic and harmonic behaviors.

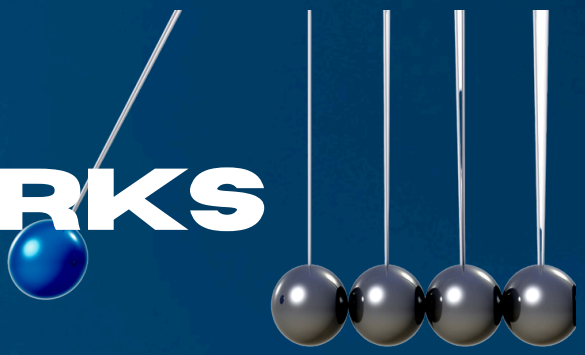
Instead of simply looking as modes as "rearrangments" of the notes of a major scale (which is commonly the way we learn modes in the Western world), we would like to propose that we utilize more of Eastern approach, which sees in each mode a character, an entire emotional universe.

Understanding the characteristics and "ethos" (emotions) of each mode allows us to develop better ear training, arrangement ideas, fluency when improvising, and an overall musical intelligence.

For the purpose of improvisation and composition, we will focus on 4 modes today. There are many more out there, so feel free to expand your practice into other directions and modes from other parts of the world.

One of the main characteristics of modal music is that it is harmonically static; The chord movements are fairly reduced, and many times not even existent. This is very different from current Jazz chord-scale theory that assigns different modes to different chords, basically treating them as mere scales.

HOW THIS WORKS



For each mode, we will be highlighting an easy way to memorize its internal structure, identify the most important notes (the notes that carry the emotional "ethos"), and demonstrating a few harmonic progressions that can be used on each mode to highlight its unique sound.

The major an minor scales can also be treated as modes (respectively the ionian and aeolian), but that implies using a rather static harmony without tonal relationships, which is quite rare.

We have coined the term "PENDULUM CHORDS" to describe these simple chord progressions which can be repeated and looped endlessly helping to create the color universe of that mode. These chords are sometimes called modal color chords.

Memorizing the pendulum chords of each mode is an extremely effective way to intuitively remember the modes and recognize modal passages in the repertoire around you.

As always, the best way to internalize any musical concepts is by composing a piece of music utilizing that concept. When I took composition classes with the late Malcolm Peyton at the New England Conservatory, he would make me write dozens of melodies (composition fragments) in each different mode, trying to highlight the most important notes in each of those. Many of those fragments ended up becoming parts of my larger scale compositions.

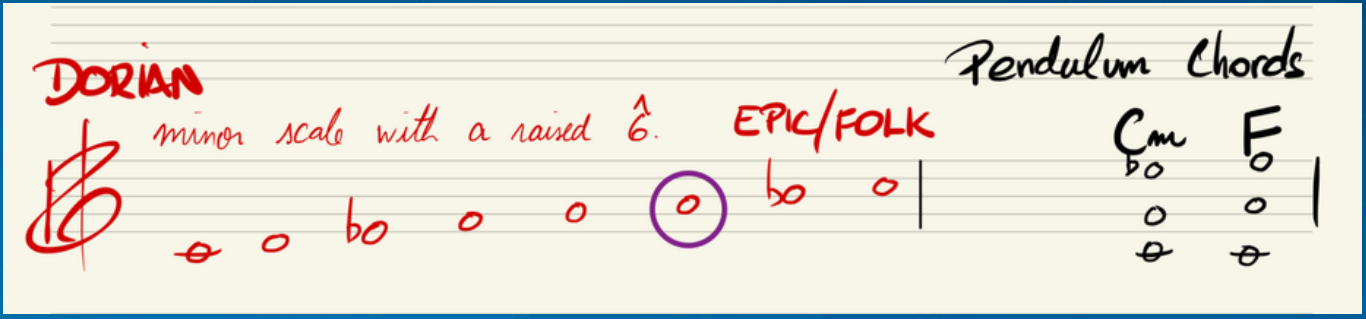


DORIAN

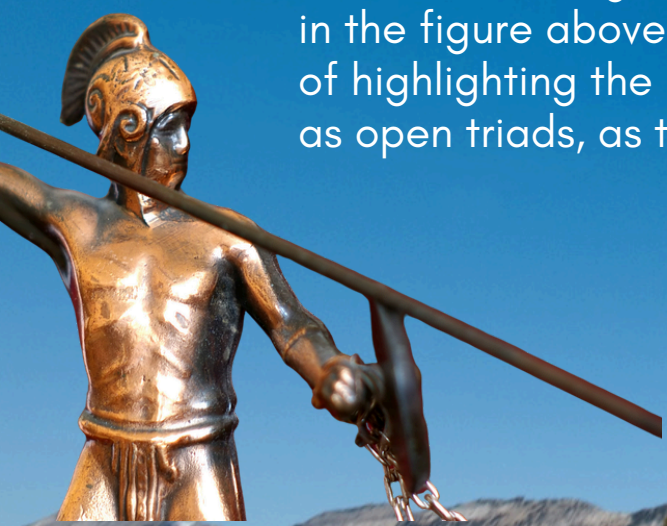
Dorian may be the most common mode in current popular music. You can hear it in filmscores, Coltrane solos, folk celtic music, Ravel, Bartok, Paul McCartney and more.

One good way to remember the Dorian mode is to think of a **NATURAL MINOR SCALE WITH A RAISED 6th.**

Needless to say, that raised 6th is the one doing all the heavy lifting in Dorian mode — it's the note responsible for that FOLK/EPIC/HEROIC feeling that makes you want to pick up a sword or tend to some goats. Composers love dropping this scale into any scene involving a small medieval village, peasants dancing in a circle, and at least one person who definitely knows how to make bread from scratch



The Dorian mode is very often accompanied by a pendulum movement that goes from the i chord to the IV chord (Cm to F in the figure above). The choice of chords is based on the idea of highlighting the "special note" of each chord. I wrote them as open triads, as those sound much better than closed triads.

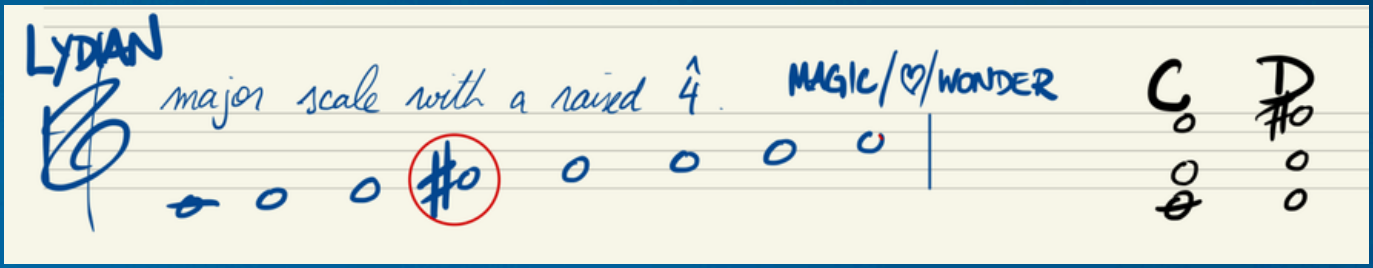


LYDIAN

Lydian is also a staple of film music, and it carries a magical cound often associated with love, marvel, wonder, magic.

One good way to remember the Lydian mode is to think of a **MAJOR SCALE WITH A RAISED 4th.**

The raised 4th is the note that carries the ethos of the Lydian. You can hear this note played over and over the soundtrack of E.T. to represent the wonder and of the extraterrestrial universe. In the tradition of Indian Classical music, the raga Yaman - known as the raga of love - has the same structure as Lydian.



It's common to use the I and II chords as pendulum chords to create a Lydian atmosphere.

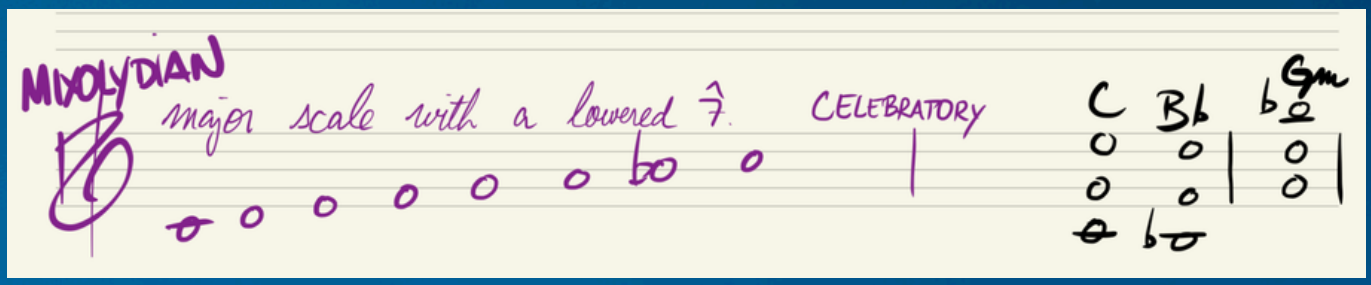


MIXOLYDIAN

Mixolydian carries an ethos of Celebration, Confidence, Joy and Triumph. It is common in folk music of Northeastern Brazil, as well as Rock songs, gospel, and olther folk cultures.

One good way to remember the Mixolydian mode is to think of a **MAJOR SCALE WITH A lowered 7th.**

The minor 7th carries the ethos of the mode. This is very familiar mode, often used over dominant chords. I personally prefer when it is used in a modal context, without any resolutions.



The pendulum chords are either I and bVII or I and v. Both sound great.

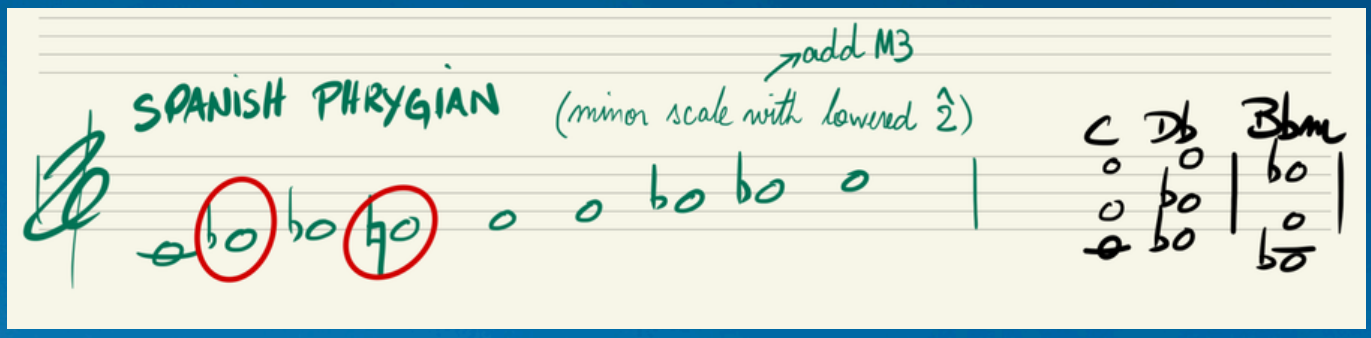


SPANISH PHRYGIAN

The Phrygian mode is rarely used as it is. But one specific variation of it has become very common in several different genres: the Spanish Phrygian, aka Flamenco scale. It is also very similar to the Hijaz makam in Middle Eastern music.

One good way to remember the Spanish Phrygian mode is to think of a **NATURAL MINOR SCALE WITH A LOWERED 2nd and an added MAJOR 3rd.**

Having both a major and minor 3rd allow for a very unique and interesting sound; Chick Corea uses it a lot in his tune *La Fiesta*. The Spanish Phrygian carries an ethos of exoticism (I hate this word, because it implies a certain orientalism to the mode), but also desire, tension, drama, fate. Ravel also uses is a lot (probably due to his basque origins).



The pendulum chords are either I and bII or I and bvii. Both sound great.



HOW TO PRACTICE

Here are some practice ideas:

- First explore each mode separetly, playing (or recording) the pendulum chords as a slow rubato progression and then improvising slow melodies over the chords, really feeling the different colors of each note and the gravity (pull) that each notes has.

- Practice quickly transposing modes to different keys. For example, try to quickly play a Ab lydian with no mistakes.

- Connecting modes: choose a pair o random modes in different keys, e.g. D spanish phrygian and G dorian. Stay on each of them for about 20 seconds and then shift to the other. Try the same thing with a harder pair of modes, for example Eb mixolydian and A lydian; You will have to find common tones and seamless ways to connect those two modes.

- Practice playing a tune such as Flamenco Sketches by Miles Davis, which contains 5 different modes over which you can improvise.

- Try establishing an ostinato using the notes of the mode. Record that ostinato, or play it on your left hand, while improvising over it. Take as an example the Children Songs of Chick Corea, especially No. 3 or No. 6 as a reference.



MORE IDEAS

- Explore the same exercises over modes that are less common, such as the whole-tone scale, the octatonic, double augmented scales, neapolitan scales, different maqam from the middle east, ragas from India, Half-Tizita scale from Ethiopia.

- Experiment creating unique voicings within a mode. Pick an unusual group of notes from the mode (avoiding conventional 3rds), and move this voicing up and down the mode, creating unique colors.

- Apply odd meters to modal ostinati, trying to emulate the sound of Balkan modal music (very common in the music of Tigran Hamasyan or Avishai Cohen).

- Create "Modal Parodies", in which you take a well known piece (any genre) and play it only using the notes of a given mode. I recommend starting with an easy mode. For example, take a simple tune like Donna Lee, or Fur Elise, and play it all in D dorian (white notes on the piano). The harmony will feel static, but that's the point. Finding new textures, figurations and ideas within the constraint of the mode



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